White[17] has pointed out five major functions of diplomacy:

1. Information gathering
2. Policy advice
3. Representation
4. Negotiation
5. Consular services

Some basic functions of diplomacy are discussed below:

Representation: The diplomat is the symbolic, legal and political representative of his country and government. His **symbolic** functions involve attending ceremonial and social occasions, address foreign groups and be present in all events with which his country has a connection. In their symbolic capacity, the diplomats have to deal with the totality of relations in all its facets between their government and their host country.

As the **legal and political** representative of the country, he conducts negotiations, signs treaties, represents his country in international conferences and organizations, and casts vote according to the directives of his government. He is also involved in the protection of interests of his country abroad and protects nationals abroad. He is also supposed to gather information and report to his government, which are like raw materials, which help the government to chalk out its foreign policies. Morgenthau points out, “As the foreign office is the nerve center of foreign policy, so are the diplomatic representatives its outlying fibres maintaining the two-way traffic between the center and the outside world”.

Negotiation: This is by far the most important function of diplomacy. This involves a variety of activities ranging from simple consultation, exchange of views to full-fledged negotiation of specific issues. Negotiation can be conducted through persuasion, compromise, inducement and even pressure. It is said that the ability to persuade other governments is central to the art of diplomacy. If persuasion fails, then other measures are available, for example, imposing time limits on the negotiation, seeking to isolate the other state diplomatically or, in extreme situations, the threat of breaking off diplomatic relations. Overall, the negotiation has to take into account